

Red Eye Red Flags for Virtual Care

Clinical Case Quiz



A 44-year-old man books a telephone appointment for red eye. He reports waking up today with a left red eye “out of nowhere.” The patient is an otherwise healthy adult who denies contact lens and eye medication use. There has been no recent eye trauma or injury. He says he is not sure what happened, but when he looked in the mirror this morning before work he saw “a bloody area in one part of the eye.”

He denies any associated eye pain, visual loss, eye discharge, eyelid swelling, diplopia or headache. On further questioning, he also denies

any floaters, flashes, halos, or dark curtains over his field of vision.

What is the most likely diagnosis and best plan of care?

- Uveitis. Recommend in-person exam and ophthalmology consult.
- Allergic conjunctivitis. Start supportive care with artificial tears and antihistamines.
- Globe trauma. Instruct patient to patch eye and come immediately to the nearest UC or ER.
- Subconjunctival hemorrhage. Instruct patient to take a photograph and obtain Patient Picture Request to confirm diagnosis and reassure.
- Corneal abrasion. Start combination antibiotic and steroid eye drops.

The answer is d.

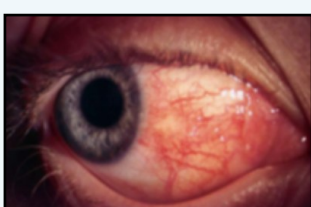
Background

Red eye is a common ophthalmic presentation in primary care and emergency room settings. According to data from the National Institutes of Health (NIH), eye complaints—particularly red eye—consistently account for 2-3% of primary care visits annually.¹ Common ocular issues, such as conjunctivitis (“pink eye”—46%) and dry eye (31%) are frequently the culprit. However, some patients with red eye may present with sight-threatening conditions.

Differential Diagnosis of Red Eye

Ocular Surface Disorders

- Dry eye
- Allergic conjunctivitis
- Contact lens overwear
- Episcleritis

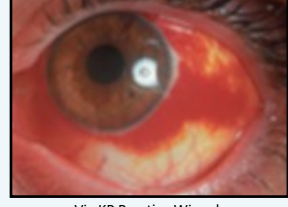


Episcleritis. Via KP Practice Wizard.



Allergic conjunctivitis. Via KP Practice Wizard.

Subconjunctival Hemorrhage



Via KP Practice Wizard.

Common Red Eye Diagnoses

- Blepharitis
- Pterygium/pingueculum
- Viral or bacterial conjunctivitis
- Corneal ulcer*
- Scleritis*
- Uveitis*
- Angle closure glaucoma*
- Endophthalmitis*



Blepharitis. Via KP Practice Wizard.



Pterygium/pingueculum. Via KP Practice Wizard.



Viral or bacterial conjunctivitis. Via KP Practice Wizard.

***In-person examination and direct consultation with an ophthalmologist recommended.**

Flagging Patients for In-Person Examination

Determining Who Needs to Be Seen In Person

- Many patients with a complaint of red eye are appropriate to manage virtually.
- Certain historical features or presenting signs and symptoms should signal you when it is appropriate to recommend an in-person examination.
- There is some emerging evidence that virtual consultation for red eye can result in accurate diagnosis and, sometimes, decreased need for in-person visits.²

Red Flag Symptoms for Red Eye

Red Flag Symptoms for Red Eye	
Ocular pain (acute onset, progressive nature, pain not relieved by analgesia, or keeping patient awake at night)	Visual loss (sudden or sustained visual loss may indicate an acute vascular event)
Photophobia (possible corneal involvement)	Trauma (sudden eye pain while using power tools, blunt trauma to eye)
New onset binocular double vision	Recent ocular surgery (within 14 days)
“Positive” visual symptoms (flashes or floaters, presence of black curtain across field of vision, halos around lights)	Ipsilateral headache (possible temporal arteritis)

Concerning Video Exam Findings with Red Eye

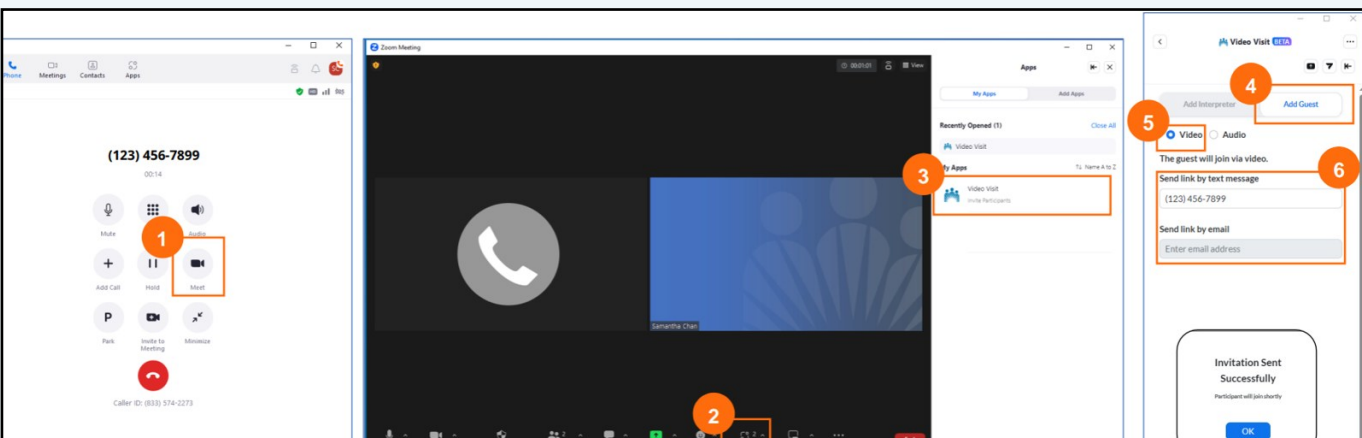
Concerning Video Exam Findings with Red Eye	
Rash in V1 distribution (ophthalmic branch of trigeminal nerve—may involve ipsilateral forehead, upper eyelid, and/or nose. Lesions involving tip of the nose “Hutchinson’s sign” = higher chance ocular movement)	Anisocoria (may indicate severe inflammation, trauma, 3 rd nerve palsy)
Periorbital swelling	Eyeball tenderness on self-palpation
Proptosis (may indicate infection, trauma, tumor, thyroid disease)	Corneal whitening (may indicate infection, inflammation, edema)

Navigating Virtual Appointments

Options for Red Eye Telephone Appointments

- A picture can be worth a thousand words!**
- Option 1:** Convert Get Care Now phone appointment for red eye to a video visit. From Zoom call, follow steps 1-7 on chart below to send a new visit invitation to the patient. Use LOS for video visit.
- Option 2:** Obtain a picture of the eye(s) through Patient Picture Request (PPR). This feature is now located in HealthConnect and available to all providers.

Convert Zoom Call to Video Visit

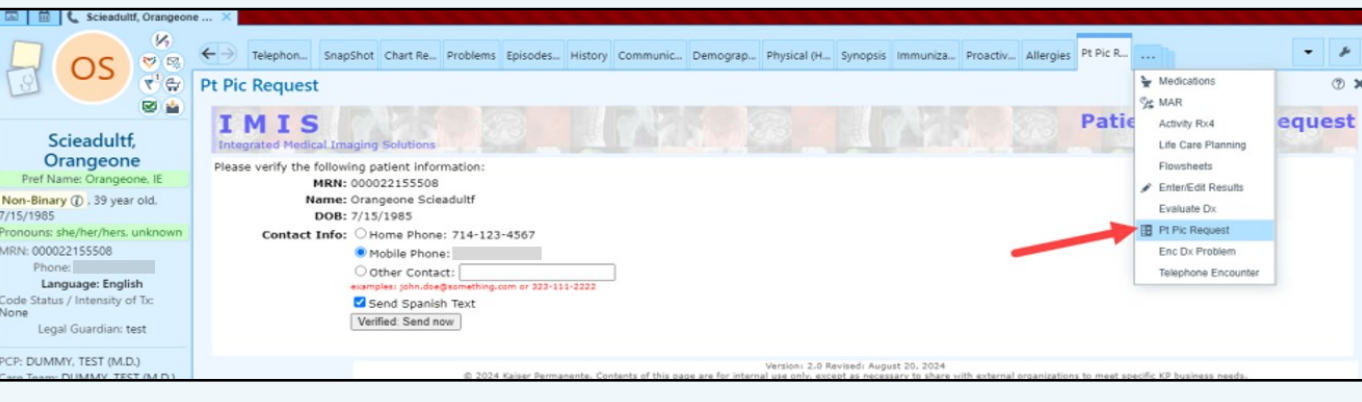


- From your Zoom Call with a member, click on “Meet”.
- In the active Zoom meeting, select the **Apps** icon on your Zoom Toolbar.
- Select the **Video Visit App Plug-in** to arrange the guest features.
- Click on the **Add Guest** button to send a link to the patient.
- Ensure the **Video** button is selected.
- Enter the patient’s preferred method to receive the link (**text message or email**).
- Click **Invite**. A message will pop-up indicating the link was sent successfully.

Patient Picture Request (PPR)

The Patient Picture Request (PPR) activity is now available for Telehealth visit encounters as a way for patients to send images in real time. The **Pt Pic Request** activity tab is available in the encounter.

- A patient’s mobile number defaults when you open the activity.
- A patient can request a text be sent to a different mobile number or email address in the **Other Contact** field.
- To send these text and email messages in Spanish, select the **Send Spanish Text** box.
- Once the message is sent, you must provide the patient with a four-digit PIN to confirm their identity.
- Patients receive a text or email and can upload up to four images at a time.



- When the patient uploads images, refresh the page to view them.
- Click the thumbnails to in and enlarge the images.
- When you finish viewing the images, click **Enter Description to Finish Transaction** to enter a description of the images, so that they can be saved to the **Media** tab.

Key Takeaways

- Screening for red-flag symptoms and signs can determine which virtual visit patients with red eye concerns require in-person examination.
- Patient Picture Request (PPR) is now part of HealthConnect and can aid in the evaluation of virtual red eye patients.
- Recommend prompt in-person evaluation and possible ophthalmology consult for patients with red eye and symptoms such as ocular pain, ipsilateral headache, loss of vision or double vision, photophobia, and recent trauma or surgery.

Appendix

- Shields, T. & Sloane, P. D. (1991). A comparison of eye problems in primary care and ophthalmology practices. *Family Medicine*, 23(7), 544-546. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/1936738/>
- Ho, C., Avery, A., Livingstone, I. A. T., & Ting, D. S. J. (2021). Virtual consultation for red eye. *British Medical Journal*, 373, 1490. <https://www.bmj.com/content/373/bmj.n1490>
- Images and referral recommendations adopted from KP SCAL Practice Wizard Red Eye (Reviewed May 2025).